Get Up, Stand Up - Station 19 (Season 4, Episode 12)

By Krista Vernoff

with contributions from Station 19's writing/support staff and cast

To be performed by a black actor

Characters:

Diane Lewis: *In the wake of national outcry after the murder of George Floyd, Captain Maya Bishop brings in Dr. Lewis to grief counsel the team.*

Ben Warren: *Previously a surgical resident and anesthesiologist. He is the first to seek out counseling with Diana and opens up about his fears and the struggles of raising black sons in the current political climate.*

Victoria Hughes (Vic): *A young mixed-race firefighter struggling to deal with Floyd's death and the media coverage. She struggles to understand how people (white people) didn't know that racism is still problematic.*

Robert Sullivan: *Trying to cope with the realization that police brutality and systemic racism won't go away if no one speaks out.*

INTRODUCTION

Eight minutes and 46 seconds. That's how long a white Minneapolis police officer knelt on George Floyd's neck, while he was handcuffed and face down on the pavement, screaming out that he couldn't breathe. Floyd's murder on May 25, 2020 sparked a renewed effort against police brutality and systemic racism.

In April 2021, ABC's Station 19 *aired an episode hailed as one of the most powerful reflections of George Floyd's murder on television. In this selection we hear the raw emotions of 3 of Station 19's black first responders as they work through their fear, anger and grief with Counselor Dr. Diane Lewis.*

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BEN: *(Enters, he is exhausted)* How do you do it? I mean, how do you. . . I-I-I know you have to be as shaken up as I am, so how do you. . .

DR. LEWIS: How do I do my job? You fought a fire this morning. How did you do it?

BEN: I pushed my pain aside and did what had to be done. *(long beat)* I feel like a hypocrite. *(long beat)* When the police made me lie down on the street like an animal during a routine traffic stop. . . I didn't do much of anything at all. I did yell, you know, whi. . . which was . . . Yeah. I have two kids.

Anyway, m-my wife and I, we . . . We gave "the talk" and explained that young Black men don't get to behave any old way they want when dealing with the police. We told them to do whatever it took to get home safe. But when I had a run-in with the police myself, I . . . I-I yelled at that officer as he got into his car. I mean, if my boys had yelled at a cop like that, I... I'd be upset! I'd . . . *(Sighs)* But I'd also be proud. . . Because they'd be right. You know, I was right. But y-you can't do that. You can't yell at a cop because, you know, w. . . Because they've got a gun, you know? They're given authority. They have the power t. . . *(Sighs)* D-Do you have kids?

DR. LEWIS: Three teenagers.

BEN: Oh, wow. Okay, so, you get just how frustrating and infuriating it is to pour every ounce of energy and brain power you have into them to. . . To try and mold them into confident young men. . . To make them honestly believe that they can accomplish anything, to. . . to work so hard to get them to s-stand tall and feel good in their own skin. . . Only to then have to tell them that because of the color of that skin, they have to shrink when in the presence of a police officer.

DR. LEWIS: Do you tell them that? Do you tell them to shrink?

BEN: No. No, I. . . I don't tell them to shrink. I. . . *(Sighs)* I tell them to stand with dignity, and I tell them to de-escalate. I-I tell them that in any confrontational situation, their job is to de-escalate. But it should be the cop's job.

DR. LEWIS: You're right. It should. *(Clears throat)* So, let me just make sure I have this straight. You're mad at yourself that you didn't do more after that cop treated you that way, and you're mad at yourself that you didn't do less after that cop treated you that way.

BEN: Look. . . I'm exhausted, you know? *(Stammers)* I'm exhausted by navigating a. . . a w. . . a world that sees me and. . . And my kids as a threat. I mean, it's. . . it's this. . . It's this constant nagging worry that. . . That never goes away. And i-if I do manage to forget and just. . . You know, just exist. . . a comment or a look or the news that a man has been killed in the street reminds me that I have to be careful. And. . . And it steals all of my

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mental and emotional energy that I should be giving to my wife and my kids. *(long beat)* Being Black in America is a life-threatening condition.

****** Scene ******

VIC: *(Enters and paces in frustration) (Sighs)* I like to fix things. I see a fire and I put it out. But we have been having this same fight for so long. . . For so long. I mean, my grandma used to tell me about the sit-ins and boycotts she used to do in the '60s. And we're how many moments and movements and marches later, and what do we have to show for it? And to see so many people act like this is news. . . Like this is just some brand-new information they're just now waking up to.

Do you know how many white friends texted me or emailed me just out of the blue? *(Laughs)* Right? And everything under this guise of just checking in and just asking how I was doing. "How are you feeling?" *(Laughs)* I knew they meant well, but I also knew what was behind it. . . guilt. So, I. . . Pbht. I don't know, how am I feeling? *(long beat)* Yeah. Yeah.

T-T-The spin already afoot by usual suspects in the media trying to vilify him rather than the murder of him. You kn. . . You know what's almost equally as enraging to me, too? It's the people patting themselves on the back trying to humanize him. It's like, you're trying to humanize a ***person***. *(Exhales sharply)* Do you really have to look for proof that we're people, too? *(Scoffs)* Really?

We should care more about him because he was a. . . A good father or a loving brother or a high-school athlete or he's fun at a party? No, we. . . we should care about him because he was a person. *(Voice breaking)* George Floyd shouldn't have been treated this way because he's a ***person***. A cop. . . should not have had his knee on his neck until the last gasp of life was choked out of him, because he is a ***person***.

****** Scene ******

SULLIVAN: *(Enters – he is visibly angry) (Sighs)* This one was different. This wasn't just another video of an innocent Black man being shot by police. This wasn't an officer making a split-

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second decision that resulted in another Black man losing his life. This wasn't fight-or-flight or panic-induced impulse or unconscious bias or unnecessary escalation.

This was the murder of an unarmed, defenseless, compliant Black man in the middle of the street in broad daylight. Right in front of our eyes. . . All of our eyes.

And, you know, white people are finally realizing that we aren't hysterical or beating a dead horse. They saw that white woman in Central Park casually use a racist police system as a weapon, and they're starting to understand that all of it renders us Black people terrorized. Hunted. Exhausted by everyday life.

And, you know, I'm tired. I'm. . . And I'm mad, and I'm sad. And I'm tired for having to explain why I'm mad and sad. I'm mad because I have to take a magic pause every time I'm being tracked by eyeballs in a store. Or when people who are in life-threatening danger choose to take their chances by themselves rather than being rescued by a Black firefighter. *(Scoffs)*

But, you know, mostly, I'm scared. I'm scared. Because no matter how tired I am, how mad I get, how sad I get, there's nothing I can say to change their minds. There's nothing I can do that will make them see me as a hardworking professional. A loving husband. Or just a man. There's nothing that prevents something like this from happening to me. Nothing. *(Sighs)*

I'm scared because I am eight minutes away from being another George Floyd. I've had so many dark thoughts. Sometimes, I doubt my own... my own goodness.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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